

taxes and tithes), or \$1,900 per month. They had difficulty making it on such a budget, even from the beginning.

Note also that they were overcommitted in the Auto and Debt categories. Those debts were the obvious result of the amount of money eaten up each month by the high house payment. When necessities came up—such as clothes, insurance, or car repairs—Ben used credit to make up the difference. The overcommitment he made regarding the cars reflected a weakness in Ben toward cars. His weakness in this area is not unusual—in fact it is quite common in most young men. During the dating years in high school and college, they place such great importance on their automobiles that they become personal status symbols. That's a poor attitude when Mom and Dad are paying the bills and the young person is still single, but it is a disaster when the young man gets married and continues to cling to the same values.

When you look at the budget for Clothing, Entertainment/Recreation, and Medical expenses, you will note that Ben and Naomi allocated nothing on a regular monthly basis for those items. That doesn't mean they found a miraculous way to keep their clothes from wearing out or their teeth from developing cavities. It means they didn't have money for those items, so they left them out of their budget. When these expenses came due—as they were bound to—Ben and Naomi had to rely on credit cards to make up the deficit. That is why so many couples say they use their credit cards only for necessities. Often that's true, except that other spending creates the need to use the cards for the necessities.

Bryan Stanford gave Ben and Naomi some suggestions to help them resolve both their immediate and their long-term problems.

1. Use the funds they already had on hand to pay the Visa bill and the outstanding balance on the car Ben had returned. Mr. Stanford made direct contact with the owner of the car lot and told him what had happened with Ben. In this case, the owner generously agreed to negotiate for a reduced amount in total payment of the bill.